to the detriment of all other players, since their tariff levels are often twice or three times lower than Russian ones: in joining the EEU they agree to forgo beneficial commercial links with Russia's direct rivals. In compensation, Russia paradoxically accepts an added cost, offering easier labour market access for the region's migrants and also cheap energy exports, advantageous loans and other forms of economic assistance. Importantly, Russia has also offered to front the bill should the WTO impose penalties on other members for raising tariffs (Popescu 2014:11–12).

These points illustrate Russia's willingness to do everything possible to attract members into the Eurasian Union and indicate beyond ambiguity that Russia is ready to put its money where its mouth is, at a time when economic sanctions, capital flight and the rouble devaluation question the viability of the EEU and have already begun hurting all EEU economies. Moscow needs to step up its support for the EEU and make sure its regional influence does not further dissipate. The ostensible political benefits for Russia go well beyond economics. Firstly, the EEU solves the angst which engulfs the Kremlin when it pictures a post-Lukashenko or post-Nazarbayev future in the region (Ukraine's violent Westward drift is something that Moscow is loath to see happening elsewhere). Additionally, the EEU not only integrates the region, but protects it from the increasing penetration of NATO and the EU, and reduces and subdues the political scope of action of local elites. Putin's Eurasian project is meant to represent post-Soviet states with an existential choice: in or out (with all their consequences). The unfolding of the Ukraine conflict over the last few months further reinforces the diametrically opposed nature of the choice offered to states between the EU and the EEU (Cadier 2014).

The EEU's chances of success are critical for Russia also in terms of its essential relations with the most powerful of the BRICS, China. In the 2000s, China and Russia were able to come together on a number of platforms and present an alternative to US/NATO unilateralism and Western hegemony. From these years emerge the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (2001), constituted by Russia, China, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Uzbekistan, and the first formal BRICS summit itself; also in these years the commercial relations between both countries grew. According to Bobo Lo, during the mid-2000s Russia became China's dominant arms supplier, including high-tech aviation equipment – more recently China reduced these imports, which it could now produce domestically (Lo 2008:79).

In the 2000s, China also became Russia's largest trading partner, surpassing Germany, in 2010 – at the same time, the differences between the two of them